K. RAGOTHAMAN (44): DSP, CBI-Madras

A post-graduate in economics, Ragothaman joined the CBI in 1968 and was appointed as the chief investigation officer of the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case. He was chosen for his good record in solving murder cases. He was known for his composure while interrogating hardened, strong-headed criminals and extracting confessions. Soft-spoken by nature, Ragothaman, however, did not succumb to pressure or threats, which is why he ran into conflicts with his seniors at times. His intentions were above board.

He formed a formidable force with Amit Verma and went deep into the investigation in spite of having no clue where to begin. It was Ragothaman who suggested that Vijay Karan visit the spot of crime—the blast site at Sriperumbudur—and adopt the procedural way from ground zero at a time when there was no clue but speculations galore. He kept the SIT apprised of the attempts and persons behind any disinformation campaign trying to malign the investigation and derail it. That way he had to face the maximum strain and stress in the SIT. Unlike other investigators, Ragothaman, being the IO of the case, had to stand in the witness box and deal with cross-examinations. In fact, the task took a toll on him and he suffered a stroke soon after the TADA court gave its verdict sentencing all the twenty-six accused to death.

AMOD KANTH (45): DIG, CBI-Delhi

A 1974-batch UT-cadre IPS officer, Amod Kanth’s rise to fame was his fearless handling of the 1984 anti-Sikh riots. Thereafter, he cracked many sensitive cases, including the assassination of Indira Gandhi and Congress leader Lalit Maken. Kanth solved the mystery of the transistor bomb blasts that killed 105 people in Delhi in 1985. He spent the next six years in the crime branch—the longest tenure for any officer—during which many more cases were solved, including the arrest of several Punjab terrorists. He was